THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

Cunningham's law

To get the right answer online, post the wrong one

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

Ask: silence
Be wrong: 47 replies

QUESTION · 3 HOURS AGO

How do I remove a file from git history?

0 replies

WRONG ANSWER · 10 MIN AGO

You can't remove a file from git history

47 replies

illustration

02 THE LAW

“The best way to get the right answer on the internet is not to ask a question; it’s to post the wrong answer”

Cunningham’s law

named by Steven McGeady in 2010, after advice from Ward Cunningham in the early ’80s

Plot twist:
he never said it

> “a misquote that disproves itself by propagating through the internet”
>
> Ward Cunningham



The wrong quote spread

Which kind of proves the law

Ward Cunningham invented the wiki

1992 coins “technical debt”
1995 builds the first wiki
2001 co-writes the Agile Manifesto

Ward Cunningham

~~Invented the wiki in 1985~~

Invented the wiki in 1995

Someone always fixes it, often in minutes

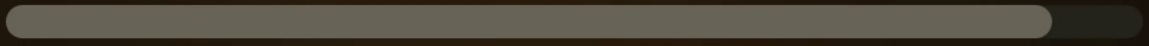
Viégas, Wattenberg & Dave · history flow, 2004 · page illustrative

Correcting is easy
Answering is work

Spot an error — seconds



Write an answer from scratch — effort



People love the easy win

Blocked? Don't ask Open a PR

TICKET · DEVOPS-482

Please add a staging queue

waiting 9 days

PULL REQUEST · #1093 · ROUGH

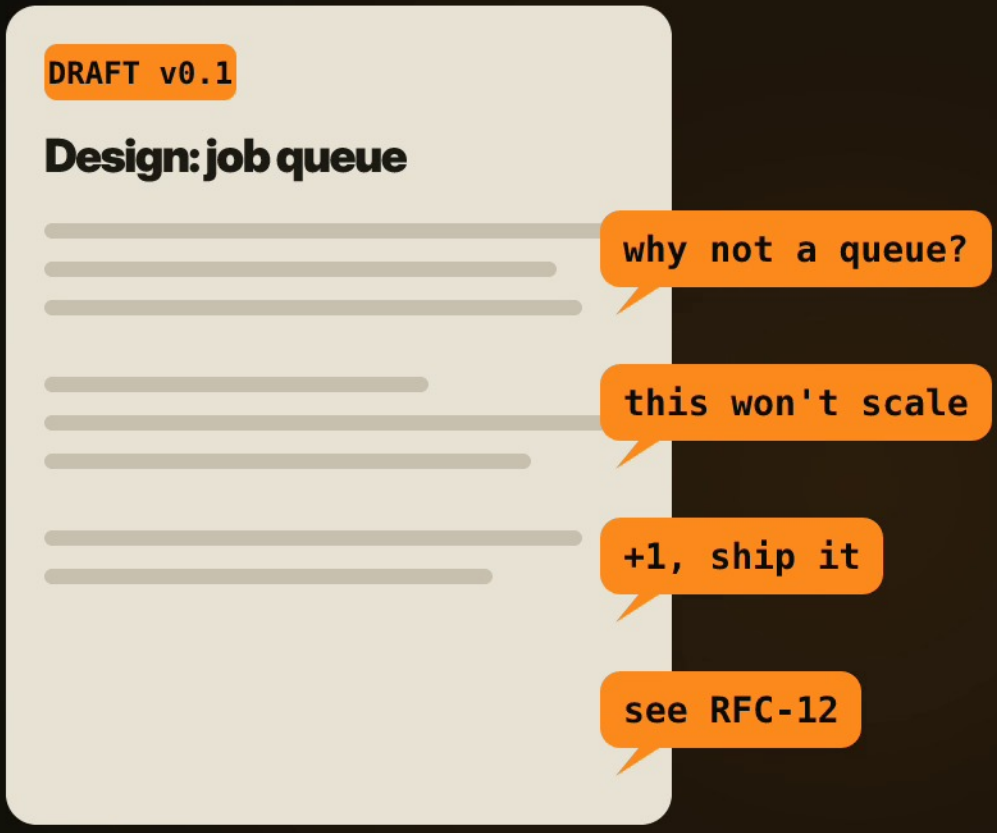
Add staging queue (copied #1041)

+42 −3 3 review comments · 1 hour

They reply fast, and you learn how

tactic via manager.dev · example illustrative

Don't ask for a design
Write a draft



Label it a draft. Let them tear it apart

08 TAKEAWAY

A rough draft gets better answers than a perfect question

YOUR DRAFT · JUST NOW

Here's my best guess
Tell me what's wrong

12 replies

TAKEAWAY

A rough draft gets better answers

than a perfect question

Sources: Ward Cunningham · Steven McGeady, 2010 · Viégas, Wattenberg and Dave, 2004 · manager.dev

next: Gall's law